

Bad Girl Gospel: The Story of Selah

A Confession About the Cost of Freedom

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Fiction Note

This is a fictional literary work. Selah is not written as a perfect victim or a complete villain. She is a character built from contradiction, desire, faith, fear, beauty, guilt, power, and the difficult work of becoming honest. This book does not celebrate harm. It asks what happens when survival becomes a performance, and freedom finally demands the truth.

Opening Manifesto

My name is Selah.

I am not your lesson, your warning, or your rehabilitation project.

You called me a baddie when you wanted my body.

You called me a bad girl when you could no longer control my heart.

You never asked what it cost me to become this untouchable.

I am not cold.

I am just done bleeding in public.

Yes, I like money.

Money means keys, exits, silence, distance.

Yes, I like attention.

I grew up invisible.

Yes, I like power.

I remember too well what it felt like to beg.

Sometimes I used people because I was tired of being the one people used first.

That does not make it right.

It only makes it true.

I have turned love into a test.

I have left people who were trying to stay.

I have stayed with people who were clearly leaving.

Don't worship me.

Understand me — or move.

I still talk to God.

In bathrooms.

In Ubers.

With glitter on my skin and guilt on my tongue.

If that makes you uncomfortable, take it to God.

I already did.

My faith was never a performance for you.

I don't want to be the good woman in your story.

I want to be the honest one in mine.

Freedom, for me, is not aesthetic.

It is not a quote on a feed.

It is the moment I stop lying about who got hurt when I finally walked out.

If I hurt you, I will not call it empowerment.

If you hurt me, I will not call it destiny.

We both carry our shadows.

I am just done carrying only mine.

A baddie is what you see.

A bad girl is what you judge.

A free woman is what I am becoming.

I am not innocent.

I am not evil.

I am becoming free.

Bad girl was just the name you gave to my freedom when it
stopped serving you.

My name is Selah.

And this is my gospel.

Chapter 1

The Rumor

No one really knew Selah. But everyone had a story about her. She's cold. She only cares about money. She ruins men for sport.

They said it in group chats and brunch lines, in Uber rides after midnight and whispered prayers on Sunday. Men talked about her like a warning. Women talked about her like a sin they condemned in public and studied in private. She walks in like the room owes her something. She wears God like jewelry and treats men like exits.

She's pretty, but she's dangerous. The kind of girl you regret out loud and miss in secret. No one told the same story twice. Facts changed. Details shifted.

Endings contradicted each other. The only thing that stayed the same was the way they said her name: like a problem, like a fantasy, like a lesson someone else was supposed to learn.

By the time Selah entered a room, the room had usually decided who she was. It did not matter what she wore. If she wore black, she was mourning someone she had destroyed. If she wore white, she was pretending to be innocent. If she wore red, they called it a confession.

If she wore nothing remarkable at all, she was trying too hard to look unbothered. The story always arrived before she did. It sat at the table. It ordered a drink. Then Selah would walk in, and everyone would pretend they had not been waiting.

She never rushed. That was one of the things they hated. Her pace made people feel watched. Her silence made people fill in blanks. Her face gave very little away, which made everyone feel like they had

discovered something.

She carried her phone like a secret and her keys like a decision already made. There was always an exit in her mind. Even when she smiled. Especially when she smiled. The men noticed first.

They always did. Not because they saw her clearly, but because they believed seeing was the same as knowing. They saw the body. The gloss. The posture.

The way she could listen without leaning in. The way she could make a man feel chosen and dismissed in the same breath. They called that power when they wanted it. They called it cruelty when they could not keep it. At tables where they pretended not to be hurt, men made Selah sound like a storm they had survived.

“She’s not normal, bro.”

“She plays games.”

“She wants you to chase her, then punishes you for running.”

“She makes you feel like you’re special, then disappears like your name was never in her phone.”

They said these things while checking if she had watched their stories and with her number still saved. They said these things with screenshots they should have deleted and memories they exaggerated into wounds. They never mentioned how quickly they had tried to rename her. Baby. Mine.

Trouble. Wife material if she calmed down. Dangerous if she did not. They never mentioned how often they mistook access for intimacy. A dinner became a claim.

A reply became a promise. A night became a contract she had never signed. They wanted a baddie until the baddie had boundaries. They wanted the picture, the body, the laugh after midnight, the soft hand on the passenger door, the woman who looked good beside

them in low light. But they did not want the part of her that said no without apology.

They did not want the part of her that could leave before the bill came if the energy changed. They did not want the part of her that knew the difference between being desired and being respected. So they called her cold. It sounded better than admitting they had been denied. And when men could not possess Selah, they turned her into a lesson.

The kind they gave to other men with fake concern and real bitterness.

“Be careful with that one.”

As if she were a road with no signs. As if they had not driven too fast. The women were more careful with their cruelty. They smiled first. They hugged her with one arm.

They complimented her shoes, her skin, her perfume, her glow. Then they studied the receipt of her life. Who paid. Who drove. Who invited her.

Who was texting. Who she arrived with. Who she left without. Women knew how to judge Selah without sounding jealous. That was an art form.

“She’s beautiful, yes. But something is off.”

“She wants attention too much.”

“She acts like she doesn’t care, but trust me, she cares.”

“She thinks silence makes her mysterious.”

They said this while copying the way she posed in mirrors. They said this while saving photos they claimed were too much. They said this while asking where she bought the dress. Selah made some women uncomfortable because she refused to apologize for being

seen. But the truth was uglier than that.

Selah reminded them of desires they had buried under good behavior. She reminded them that some cages are decorated so well people start calling them standards. She reminded them that softness, when demanded, is not softness at all. It is obedience in a prettier dress. Still, not all of them were wrong.

Selah could be sharp. She could be unfair. She could enter a friendship like she was already halfway out of it. She could give warmth in controlled amounts, like someone pouring expensive perfume onto a wrist and refusing to hand over the bottle. She knew how to be loved from a distance.

She knew how to make people miss her before she left. And sometimes she liked that. Some of the rumors were lies. Some were punishment. Some were warnings dressed as gossip.

But some were close enough to the truth to leave fingerprints. On Sundays, the church people spoke differently. They used softer words. Concern. Discernment.

Prayer request. Spirit. They never said gossip when the sentence started with “we need to pray for her.” They said Selah’s name like they were lowering it into water.

“She has a calling, but...”

There was always a but.

“She has a beautiful spirit, but...”

“She is gifted, but...”

“She needs covering.”

“She needs guidance.”

“She needs to stop confusing attention with purpose.”

They watched her lift her hands during worship and remembered what she had worn on Friday. They watched her close her eyes in prayer and wondered whose car, whose table, whose money, whose arms had carried her through the weekend. They believed God could forgive anything. But they struggled when beauty did not look sorry enough. That was Selah's quiet crime.

She did not perform shame in a language they recognized. She did not shrink after being seen. She did not lower her voice enough to make other people comfortable with her repentance. And maybe, sometimes, she was not repentant yet. Maybe sometimes she was only tired.

Maybe sometimes she came to God with glitter still on her skin because she did not know where else to go before morning. Maybe sometimes the prayer was not clean. Maybe it was just breath. Maybe it was just, "Please don't let me become what they think I am." But no one heard that part.

They only saw the lashes. The nails. The dress. The late arrival. The early exit.

The way men turned their heads and women pretended not to notice. They called it discernment. Sometimes it was just envy with Bible verses on top. Online, Selah became easier to hate. People are braver when they are only a thumbnail.

Under photos, they left little knives. This one thinks she's all that. Baddie era but make it father issues. Pretty girls always think consequences are optional. She looks expensive and exhausting.

Pray for her. The last one always got likes. Selah rarely replied. That made it worse. People hate a woman who refuses to defend herself because silence leaves too much room for imagination.

So they imagined. A man with a private account said she had ruined him. A woman with a Bible verse in her bio said Selah was lost.

A stranger said she looked like the type who would choose money over love. Someone else said love was probably not choosing her either.

That one stayed with her longer than it should have. She read it in the back of an Uber, the city sliding past the window in strips of yellow and red. The driver had gospel radio playing low. Her phone light made her face look softer than she liked. For a moment, no one was watching.

For a moment, she looked less like a rumor and more like someone trying not to believe one. She opened the comment again. Then closed it. Opened a message thread. Typed three words.

Deleted them. Typed nothing. Deleted that too. She pressed her thumb against the small cross at her neck. Not dramatically.

Not like a film. Just enough to remind herself it was still there. The driver asked if the address was correct. She said yes. Then changed it.

There were things Selah did that made the rumors worse. She knew that. She did not always help herself. Sometimes she let people believe the crueller version because it was easier than offering the truth to people who had already enjoyed the lie. Sometimes she dressed like armor and acted surprised when people called her hard.

Sometimes she wanted to be held, but behaved like being needed was an insult. Sometimes she stayed long enough to be wanted and left before anyone could ask her to be known. Sometimes she used mystery because honesty felt too close to begging. And Selah did not beg anymore. At least not where people could hear.

There was one lounge where people loved to see her. Not because they loved her. Because seeing Selah gave them something to say on the way home. She arrived late, with a black coat over her shoulders and the kind of calm that made people accuse her of arrogance. Her perfume entered before her.

Soft. Expensive. Almost kind. A man near the bar stopped mid-sentence. A woman at a corner table looked down at Selah's shoes, then up at her face, then away just slowly enough to be noticed.

Someone whispered. Someone laughed. Someone lifted a phone as if checking the time. Selah saw all of it. They thought because she did not react, she did not notice.

But Selah had learned to read rooms before they read her. She knew the difference between admiration and appetite. Between welcome and assessment. Between concern and surveillance. Between prayer and performance.

She kissed the cheek of a woman who had spoken badly about her two nights before. The woman smiled. Selah smiled back. Both of them knew. Neither of them said.

At the table, someone asked where she had been.

"Busy," Selah said.

"With what?"

"Surviving my reputation."

Everyone laughed because they thought it was a joke. It was not exactly a joke. A man offered to buy her a drink. She thanked him and ordered water. He looked offended, as if sobriety had rejected him personally.

Another man asked why she always looked like she was about to leave. Selah smiled.

"Because I usually am."

Her phone buzzed on the table. For half a second, her face changed. Almost nothing. A small pause behind the eyes. The kind of thing only loneliness notices in other people.

She turned the phone over without reading the message. Then turned it back. Then did not open it. Across the room, a woman watched and decided this meant Selah was playing games. A man watched and decided this meant someone had power over her.

A friend watched and decided not to ask. That was how rumors survived. Not because people knew too much. Because they could not stand not knowing enough. Selah went to the bathroom before midnight.

The mirror was large, gold-framed, too honest. Women came in and out behind her, carrying lipstick, laughter, secrets, and the small violence of comparison. Selah washed her hands slowly. She looked at herself the way someone checks a locked door. Still there.

Still composed. Still expensive enough to be misunderstood. She imagined walking back into the lounge and telling the truth badly. I am tired. I am afraid.

I liked being wanted because I grew up invisible. I left before they could leave me. I have hurt people who were only trying to love me. I don't always know where the woman ends and the character begins. The door opened.

Two women entered laughing.

"Oh my God, you look amazing."

"Thank you."

"So unfair. You always look like life can't touch you."

Life had touched her everywhere. In places no dress could show and no rumor could explain.

"That's the idea," Selah said.

The women laughed. Selah left. Behind her, one of them whispered, "See? Cold." They could watch a woman build a wall with

bleeding hands and still call her distant because they did not get a door. Later, in another Uber, Selah finally read the message.

It was from someone she had not saved under his real name anymore. That was one of her rules. Never let the phone look too much like the heart. I saw you tonight. No hello.

No apology. No explanation. Just that. I saw you tonight. She stared at it until the words became less like a message and more like an accusation.

Another one came through. You looked happy. People were always mistaking performance for evidence. She typed: You saw what I allowed.

Deleted it. Typed: You don't know what happy looks like on me. Deleted that too. Locked the phone.

Outside, the city kept its secrets in closed shops, wet pavement, traffic lights, and windows where strangers lived entire lives without becoming stories. Selah leaned her head back and closed her eyes. The radio changed from music to late-night talk. Someone was discussing forgiveness. She hated when God followed her into cars.

Not because she did not believe. Because she did. Because some part of her still thought heaven knew her name before the streets turned it into a headline. Because some part of her still hoped God could see the woman without clapping for the character. The phone buzzed again.

She did not look. Not yet. There was power in not looking. There was also fear. Selah had become very good at confusing the two.

By noon, Selah was no longer a woman who had gone out, checked her phone, touched a cross, and gone home carrying more silence than sleep. She had become content. A theory. A cautionary tale in heels. A body people named before they knew what it had survived.

And maybe that was the oldest rumor of all. Not that Selah was cold. Not that she used men. Not that she loved money. Not that she prayed with guilt on her tongue.

The oldest rumor was the one people told about women like her before they ever opened their mouths: that beauty is evidence, that attention is consent, that silence is arrogance, that softness must be public to be believed,

that if a woman looks untouchable, she must have asked to be lonely. But no one really knew Selah. They only knew the version of her that made their own stories easier to tell. They called her bad because she stopped being available for their version of love. They called her dangerous because she learned to leave with her keys in her hand and her name still in her own mouth.

They called her untouchable because they never understood the difference between a wall and a wound. By the time Selah entered the room, the room had already decided what kind of woman she was. And before anyone knew her story, they had already named her body.

Chapter 2

The Body

Before they ever knew her name, they knew her body. Not the story written inside it. Not the nights it carried home alone. Not the years it took to become this deliberate. Just the outline.

The waist. The legs. The mouth. The parts that fit into conversations and fantasies more easily than into prayers. Selah noticed early that people reacted to her before she did anything.

Walk into a room, and the air moved. Say good morning, and someone heard invitation. Ask for help, and someone heard promise. It took her a while to understand: some people were not listening to her.

They were listening to what her body triggered in them. It was a strange kind of fame. Being known by shape instead of by history. As a teenager, she thought beauty was a compliment. Later, she learned it was also a currency.

And a weapon. And a target. She did not ask for the first stares. She did not sign up for the first comments. She did not volunteer for the first hands that tried to “accidentally” find her waist in crowded places.

But once you realize you are being priced, weighed, measured and projected onto anyway, you only have a few options: shrink, hide, or charge. Selah chose none of those cleanly. She didn’t shrink. She didn’t fully hide.

And she didn’t just charge. She experimented. At first, The Body was an ambush. Catcalls on streets she could not afford to avoid.

Hands on buses that took her to jobs she could not afford to lose.

Eyes at family gatherings that made compliments sound like threats.

“You’re going to have to be careful,” the older women said.

They meant: men. But what they never said out loud was that sometimes the danger was not what men wanted from her, but what they thought they were owed because of it. Later, The Body became a negotiation. Dress down, you’re “humble”. Dress up, you’re “asking for it”.

Wear less, you’re a problem. Wear more, you’re “trying to act holy”. No outfit changed the accusation. Only the vocabulary. Selah got tired of apologizing for existing in a shape other people found loud.

So she tried something new: instead of running from the attention, she walked toward it with intention. If you are going to talk anyway, she thought, then at least I will choose the picture. High heels became more than height. They became leverage.

Red lipstick became more than color. It became focus. A dress became more than cloth. It became a contract she wrote for herself: I will not make myself smaller to ease your self-control.

People called it confidence. They never saw the drafts. The nights she stood in front of a mirror wondering if she was powerful or just well-packaged. The hours spent trying to decide if she liked the way she looked, or if she only liked the way the world behaved when she looked like that. Beauty gave her things.

It opened doors that money could not yet afford. It made people listen who would have ignored her otherwise. It bought silence, favors, tables, rides, apologies that should have come without incentive. It also took things. Privacy.

Safety. The benefit of the doubt. When a pretty woman cries, people ask what she did. When a pretty woman complains, people call it dramatics. When a pretty woman says no, people hear “convince me”.

Selah learned to read the delay between eye contact and eye drop. She learned to recognize the moment admiration turned into entitlement. A slight lean in. A joke that only worked if she accepted being the punchline. A hand that stayed too long.

She hated that she could feel danger with her skin before she could form words for it. The Body was also an alibi.

“It’s easy for you,” some women said.

“As long as you look like that, you’ll be fine.”

They said it like beauty was armor, not also magnet and liability. They said it like pretty girls could not be lonely. Like pretty girls could not be used. Like pretty girls could not be abandoned, only replaced. Sometimes Selah wanted to ask them:

If beauty is such a blessing, why do so many of us feel like a crime scene? But she didn’t. There is no polite way to explain that compliments feel like traps when they always come with expectations. There were nights when she used The Body on purpose. Walked past someone she knew was watching.

Chose a table where being seen was part of the game. Accepted a drink she could have bought herself, because sometimes letting someone else pay was her way of saying: You think this makes us even. It doesn’t. She was not innocent in this. She enjoyed power.

She liked knowing she could move a room without saying much. She liked the way silence felt when people were waiting to see if she would look back. She also paid for it. Every time she posted a picture, a new theory about her soul appeared in the comments. Every time she wore something tight, someone assumed they were now allowed

to speak loose.

Every time she looked like a fantasy, someone forgot she was a person. The worst part was not being looked at. The worst part was being edited. Stripped down and rearranged in other people's imagination. Turned into a type.

A foil. A cautionary tale their daughters should not become. A secret their sons would not admit wanting. Men said, "You know what you're doing," as if that excused everything they did in response. Women said, "If I looked like you, I'd do the same," as if harm done with beauty hurt less.

They did not understand that sometimes Selah dressed like that not to seduce, but to survive. Because in a world that has already decided your body is loud, sometimes the only way to feel safe is to decide that if they are going to watch, at least you will choose when, where, and how. There was a time when The Body belonged to other people's words. Pretty. Thick.

Curvy. Exotic. Too much. Just enough. Dangerous.

They said all of it like a diagnosis. Like their opinion turned into law as soon as it left their mouths. Then came a quieter time. Not softer. Just quieter.

Selah started standing in front of mirrors without an audience in mind. Not asking, "Will they like this?" Asking, "Can I stand myself like this?" On some days, she could. On some days, she couldn't.

On some days, she wasn't sure if the discomfort came from modesty, lust, trauma, or simple fatigue. What she knew was this: Her body had been a battlefield long before she ever chose a side. People had claimed territory with words and hands and rules and warnings. People had built altars and courtrooms out of her silhouette.

People had sacrificed her complexity in the name of their self-control. The Body had been blamed for desires that were never

hers alone. The Body had been punished for fantasies she did not write. The Body had been used as evidence in trials she was never allowed to testify in. So when they called her vain, she let them.

They had called her worse when she didn't recognize herself at all. When they called her "doing too much," she agreed in private. Not because of the dress. Because of the exhaustion of always calculating how much skin equalled how much safety. When they accused her of using her looks, she did not flinch.

There were years when everyone else had used them but her. If there is a sin in how Selah wore The Body, it was not that she enjoyed being desired. It was that sometimes she accepted desire as a substitute for respect. It was that sometimes she confused being chosen with being seen. It was that sometimes, when she felt empty, she let attention pour into places that needed healing, not applause.

She knew this. She could not always stop herself. The Body made certain mistakes look glamorous. It dressed poor decisions in good lighting. It made her think she was in control while she was repeating patterns.

Later, in the dark, with no filters and no audience, the same body told the truth. In the way her shoulders tensed when a stranger stood too close. In the way her stomach clenched before messages from certain names. In the way her heart sped up when she walked past groups of men at night. In the way her knees had once shaken in a bathroom stall when she realized a "joke" had not been a joke at all.

There were things that had happened to Selah that people would have taken more seriously if she had looked smaller, plainer, quieter. But The Body complicated the narrative. Beauty always does. People prefer their victims obviously fragile. Their survivors obviously grateful.

Their bad girls obviously evil. Selah was none of those cleanly. She was a woman whose body had been praised, blamed, worshipped and

indicted. A woman who had learned to weaponize what once left her defenseless. A woman who now had to untangle which parts of her power were real and which were just reactions to old fear.

If rumor was the story they told about her, The Body was the proof they thought they had. They looked at the curve of her hips and called it temptation. They looked at the line of her back and called it arrogance. They looked at the way she took up space and called it pride.

They never saw the little girl who learned to walk quickly past building sites. The teenager who wore hoodies in summertime because she was tired of commentary. The young woman who realized the hoodie did not stop the comments, it just changed their tone. At some point, Selah stopped dressing for safety because safety never showed up. She started dressing for truth.

Sometimes the truth was: I want to feel desired tonight. Sometimes the truth was: I want to feel invisible. Sometimes the truth was:

I want to feel like I belong to myself. The Body could not do all of that. But it could remind her of one thing: If they are going to name me anyway, I will not abandon myself in the process. They thought The Body was the most interesting thing about her.

It wasn't. But it was the first thing they misread. And like most first impressions, it took a long time to correct. The rumor said her beauty was the problem. The truth was simpler and uglier:

Her beauty made it easier for people to lie about what they did with their own desire. They blamed The Body. She carried the consequences. One day, much later, Selah would learn to look at herself and say: This is my body.

It has been worshipped, used, desired, feared, blamed and adored. It has walked me out of places I should never have entered. It has

survived nights I do not talk about. It is not a crime scene. It is not a trophy.

It is not an apology. It is mine. But that understanding was still a few chapters away. For now, all the world saw was the outline. The rumor had a shape now.

Hips. Mouth. Legs. Eyes. They called it temptation. They called it distraction. They called it dangerous. They forgot The Body was carrying a heart that had not yet decided if freedom was worth all this misinterpretation.

And that heart, for the moment, was still hiding behind the only thing the world seemed interested in: the body they had already turned into a story.

Chapter 3

The Money

Before Selah ever chased money, she chased distance. Distance from the wrong house. Distance from the wrong hands. Distance from the version of herself that had to ask for everything. Money just happened to be the cleanest way to buy that distance.

People said, “She only cares about money,” like it was a personality trait. They never said it like a survival strategy. They imagined luxury. What they never pictured was the first time Selah counted coins at the back of a bus and realized she could not afford to leave somewhere she no longer felt safe. You remember moments like that.

You remember the night you stay in a room because your bank account tells you to. You remember the sick feeling of calculating how much danger you can budget for. You remember promising yourself: Never again. Later, when they saw her in taxis instead of back seats, in hotel lobbies instead of spare couches, in restaurants where nobody shouted over each other, they called it “liking the soft life.”

They hadn’t seen the hard one. Selah’s relationship with money did not start with designer things. It started with wanting options. Options like: A cab when the energy shifts.

A room of her own when someone raises their voice. A plane ticket when the city feels too small for all the versions of her people have invented. Money looked like freedom long before it looked like status. As a child, she noticed who had to ask and who didn’t. Who could leave a table when the mood changed and who had to swallow it.

Who negotiated. Who obeyed. It was rarely about love. It was almost always about who paid.

“You can’t talk to your father like that, he pays the bills.”

“You can’t leave, he’s the one who provides.”

“You can’t complain, do you know how much this costs?”

Selah watched women shrink under receipts. She learned, quietly: The person who can leave has the power. So she decided to become the person who could leave. They called it gold digging when she refused to be broke and trapped.

They called it independence when they liked the aesthetic. Selah stopped caring about the word. She cared about the door it opened. The first real money she made did not look glamorous. It smelled like tired feet, long shifts, late trains.

It sat in her account in numbers that were still small, but finally hers. She did not rush to buy a bag. She bought time. Time away from people who spoke to her like she was lucky to be chosen. Time to say no to invitations that came with conditions.

Time to rest without asking permission. There is a particular silence that arrives the first time you realize: If this goes wrong, at least I can pay for my own exit. That silence is addictive. Later, when she started making more, the story changed.

“She likes rich men.”

“She only dates guys with money.”

“She’s leveling up.”

Some of that was true. Selah liked men who understood bills, risks, and consequences. She liked men who knew that “I’ve got you” meant more than splitting a dessert. She liked not having to explain that she would rather be alone than dependent. What they didn’t see

was this:

She didn't need a man with money. She needed a life where she didn't feel like a hostage. If a man could not match the standard she was building for herself, she didn't call him broke. She just didn't call him at all. Money complicated love.

How do you trust "I'm here because I want you" when you've seen how many people stay because they can't afford to leave? How do you believe "I'd still choose you if we lost everything" when you've watched people disappear at the first sign of less? Selah did not lie to herself. She liked nice places. Soft towels.

Good sheets. A view that did not look like escape routes. Dinners where she could order what she wanted without reciting the price in her head first. But what she loved was what those things said: I am not here because I have nowhere else to go.

She had seen the opposite. Women trapped in pretty houses they did not own. Wives smiling in photos and crying in closets. Girlfriends calling their partners "provider" with a tone that sounded more like "warden." Selah swore she would never stay because of rent.

So yes, she talked about money. Openly. Deliberately. Not as a test of income alone. As a test of honesty.

A man who flinched when she said "money" was often a man who still believed he should be able to buy control without calling it that. A man who got defensive when she brought up finances usually wanted the perks of leadership without the transparency. She preferred awkward conversations early to humiliations later. People said, "She thinks she's too good for normal guys." No.

She thought she was too old to pretend love made unpaid bills disappear. There was one dinner that taught her more than three relationships had. The restaurant was quiet, expensive, soft-lit in a way that made everyone look kinder than they were. He chose the

place. He chose the wine.

He chose the table. He corrected the waiter with the calm of a man who had never needed to raise his voice to be obeyed. Selah noticed these things. She always noticed where power sat. At first, he was generous.

The kind of generous people praised.

“Order anything,” he said.

So she did. Not the cheapest thing. Not the most expensive. Just what she wanted. He smiled like he approved.

That was the first problem. Approval always made her listen harder. Halfway through dinner, he started speaking in future tense.

“You should let me take care of things.”

“You work too much.”

“You don’t need to be so independent with me.”

The words sounded soft. The room made them softer. The money made them almost beautiful. But Selah heard the lock inside the gift. She had heard it before.

A little care. A little control. A little “I’ve got you” wrapped around a future where no one asked what she wanted anymore. When the bill came, he reached for it quickly. Too quickly.

Like a flag. Selah let him touch it. Then she placed her card beside his. He laughed.

“Don’t be like that.”

There it was. Not anger. Not yet. Just disappointment that she had refused the role. Selah smiled.

“I’m not being like anything.”

“You don’t know how to receive.”

She looked at him then. Really looked. The expensive watch. The clean nails. The mouth that had called control romance and expected gratitude to do the rest.

“No,” Selah said. “I know exactly how to receive. I just also know how to leave.”

His face changed. Only for a second. But long enough. Later, people would say she was difficult. That she ruined a nice evening.

That some women do not know how to be treated well. But Selah paid half the bill, ordered her own car, and watched his kindness expire before dessert. That was the thing about money. It did not tell her everything. But it often revealed what people thought they had purchased.

In her quiet moments, Selah admitted one thing: Money had become both shield and idol. She checked her account when she felt anxious. She calculated independence in digits. She measured safety in savings.

If the number was high, she relaxed. If it was low, everything felt closer, sharper, more dangerous. It wasn't just lifestyle. It was exits. The more exits she could fund, the less trapped she felt.

The less trapped she felt, the braver she became. Sometimes that bravery looked like wisdom. Sometimes it looked like carelessness dressed as “I'll be fine, I can always leave.” There were nights she said yes to plans because she knew she could order her own ride home. There were situations she entered thinking:

If this turns weird, I'll just go. Sometimes she went. Sometimes she didn't go fast enough. Money could open doors. It could not always close hands.

There were men who tried to use wealth as a leash. Who believed that if they paid, they owned. Who hid control under generosity.

“Don’t worry, I’ve got it.”

“Move in with me, save your money.”

“You don’t need to work so much, I can handle it.”

It sounded like care. Sometimes it was. Sometimes it was just an investment in future obedience. Selah listened not only to the offer, but to the conditions. What happens if I say no?

What happens if I disagree? What happens if I leave? She had learned this much: Any money that came with a gag order was too expensive. So she built quietly.

Stream by stream. Job by job. Creative hustle by creative hustle. People saw the results and called it soft life. They missed the spreadsheets.

The late nights. The fear. The self-teaching. The discipline. Selah did not romanticize the grind.

She was not in love with hustle culture. She was simply allergic to dependence. There is a specific humiliation to asking someone for money and watching their face change. She had seen that. Once was enough.

Did she go too far sometimes? Yes. She judged people too quickly by how they treated bills. She cut off potential stories because someone hesitated when the check came. She equated generosity with character in ways that were not always fair.

She knew that. She just did not know how else to measure trust yet. When people said, “Money can’t buy happiness,” Selah shrugged. Money had never bought her happiness. But it had bought her a therapist.

It had bought her time to fall apart without losing her home. It had bought plane tickets out of cities that reminded her too much of who she used to be. Money could not buy a healed heart. But it could buy a

mattress she slept on alone because she chose solitude over begging. That counted for something.

There was one man who told her, “You act like money is your God.” She almost laughed. If money were her God, she would have slept better. Money was not God. Money was an unreliable friend.

It came, it left, it returned with different clothes on. Sometimes it showed up right on time. Sometimes it disappeared when she needed it most. God, at least in theory, stayed. But Selah’s prayers often sounded like accounting.

“Lord, I need enough to leave if I have to.”

“Lord, I don’t ever want to be stuck.”

“Lord, I don’t want to choose between dignity and rent.”

She was not asking for yachts. She was asking for exits. People said, “She’s materialistic.” They saw shoes and bags. They did not see how many times those shoes had walked her out of danger.

They did not see what those bags had carried: documents, plans, backup cards, chargers,

condoms, anxiety meds, lipstick, a small bottle of perfume, and the version of her that could start over somewhere else if she needed to.

Luxury, for Selah, was never just about shining. It was about not shaking. Nice hotels meant locks that worked. Nice restaurants meant staff who noticed when something went wrong. Nice cars meant drivers with names, plates, and companies she could call if things went left.

She understood that these were illusions too. Bad things still happened in pretty places. But if the world was going to be unfair anyway, she refused not to use every tool she had. Sometimes she overspent. Sometimes she tried to fill a wound with something that

came in a box.

Sometimes she bought things she didn't need because it felt like proof that she was no longer that girl counting coins at the back of the bus. She was not proud of that. But she remembered how it felt to be cheap in other people's hands. Having her own card, her own key, her own account was not just about showing off. It was about knowing that if love failed, she would not have to beg love to pay for her exit.

If there was a sin in her relationship with money, it was this: She trusted it more than she trusted people. Sometimes more than she trusted God. Money had never told her, "I love you," and then disappeared. Money had never promised, "I've got you," and then turned its phone off.

Money had never begged for forgiveness and repeated the same pattern. Money either showed up or it didn't. At least that was honest. One day, she would have to untangle security from control. She would have to learn the difference between a man who could provide and a man who thought provision gave him permission.

One day, she would have to ask herself if her standards were protecting her or isolating her. But that reckoning was still coming. For now, all the world saw was this: A bad girl who liked nice things. A woman who refused broke romance.

A body in expensive fabric. They made jokes about gold diggers and soft life. They told their sons, "Girls like that will use you." They told their daughters, "Don't be like her. Be stable, be grateful." What they never admitted was how many of them secretly wanted to know what it felt like to leave a room and not worry who was paying the bill.

The rumor said Selah loved money more than love. The truth was messier: She did not trust love that came without a plan. She did not trust promises that ignored reality. She did not trust "forever" that could not survive a financial conversation.

In a world where women were told to choose between romance and security, Selah refused the choice. She wanted both. And until she was sure, she chose security first. They called it greed. She called it insurance.

But an exit plan does not only change how a woman leaves. It changes how she loves. It changes how she listens to promises. It changes how quickly she hears a lock inside a kindness. Somewhere between Rumor and Body and Money, a new label started to stick:

bad with an exit plan. They said it as an insult. Selah took it as a compliment. If they insisted on calling her a bad girl, fine. But she would at least be one with an exit plan.

Chapter 4

The Men

Selah did not hate men. That was one of the lazier rumors. She hated how often love arrived carrying instructions. Be softer. Answer faster.

Trust me sooner. Stop acting like you don't need anyone. Let me lead. Let me help. Let me in.

Let me become the reason you stop being so difficult. Men loved calling their control patience. They loved calling their appetite honesty. They loved calling their expectations love. Selah had heard every version.

The man who wanted to save her. The man who wanted to own her. The man who wanted to study her like a wound. The man who called her "different" until different became inconvenient. The man who said he loved strong women, then spent the relationship trying to make her less strong.

The man who wanted the baddie in public and the good girl in private. The man who admired her independence until her independence refused him. They were not all cruel. That was the part Selah hated most. Cruel men were easy.

Cruel men gave her something clean to leave. The complicated ones were kind. Patient. Funny. Careful with their hands.

Men who remembered small things. Men who asked if she had eaten. Men who did not flinch when she said no. Men who made safety feel less like a locked door and more like a room with light in it. Those men scared her more.

Because with cruel men, she knew who she was: the girl who leaves before it gets worse. With good men, she had no script. Just a heart that didn't know how to stay without checking where all the exits were. Selah wanted love.

She just treated intimacy like a room with no exits. The closer someone came, the louder her mind looked for doors. Say the wrong thing, and she filed it under "evidence." Show too much interest, and she called it a trap. Ask too many questions, and she decided you were an auditor, not a lover.

She did not meet every man with softness. She met many of them with a test. Answer slowly. Reply late. Disappear for a day.

Mention other plans, other options, other men whose names she did not have to say. If he stayed, she called it proof. If he left, she called it confirmation. Either way, she won the argument in her head. Selah liked to say she was "protecting her heart."

Sometimes that was true. Sometimes it was just cruelty with better lighting. She had learned early that some men only respected boundaries they found difficult. So she became difficult. Not by accident.

By design. She didn't always know how to express fear without sounding like accusation. She didn't always know how to say, "I don't trust myself to let you in," without turning it into, "I don't trust you." So she did what she knew: turned feelings into strategies.

She tested loyalty by withholding clarity. She measured interest by how much confusion a man would tolerate. She made silence into a maze and timed how long it took someone to get tired. There were patterns she could not deny. She would give warmth in doses.

Laugh, lean in, answer deeply one night. Then go quiet for three days. She would let a man talk, really talk, about his fears, his past, his dreams. Then change the subject the second he asked her to match

the vulnerability. She could turn a good conversation into a dead end with one small shrug, one vague answer, one “it’s not that deep.”

It was that deep. She just didn’t want to dig where someone else could see her hands shaking. Sometimes she used affection like credit. Spend now, panic later. Say “I miss you” and mean it in the moment, then resent the feeling the next day.

Kiss someone like a promise, then wake up allergic to what she’d implied. She confused honesty with blurting out whatever hurt, whenever it hurt. She confused transparency with confession only after she felt safe enough to leave. And yet, she wasn’t always the villain in the story. There were men who tried to own what they did not build.

Who thought buying dinner gave them access to childhood. Who believed “Tell me everything” was intimacy, not interrogation. They called it “opening up” when they really meant “arming me with your weaknesses.” Selah could feel when a man was collecting data. She did not give men like that a map.

She gave them postcards. Pretty. Vague. Souvenir-level truth. She kept the real city of her heart under construction signs.

There was one man who did not fit neatly into any category. He did not try to save her. He did not try to own her. He did not try to impress her with speeches about how different he was. He was simply there.

He texted, but not to monitor. He called, but not to demand. He showed up when he said he would and didn’t take photos to prove it. He noticed things that had nothing to do with her body.

“The way you go quiet when someone interrupts you mid-sentence.”

“How you always sit facing the door.”

“How you pretend you don’t care about birthdays, then remember everyone’s.”

He did not flinch when she pulled away in small ways. When she made jokes out of serious things. When she rolled her eyes at compliments that hit too close to need. One night, after a long day, she fell asleep on his couch mid□movie. No makeup, no pose, no curated version.

She woke up under a blanket she didn’t remember asking for. A glass of water on the table. Her phone charging. No photos. No hands where they shouldn’t have been.

No “you owe me” in his eyes. It terrified her. Safety felt like a setup. Kindness felt like prelude to a bill. She waited for the turn.

The moment he would use her softness against her. The moment he would say, “After everything I’ve done for you...” It didn’t come. So she did what she knew how to do when there was no obvious danger. She created some.

She started answering slower. She picked small arguments and stretched them. She questioned motives he had already explained. She found tiny inconsistencies and magnified them until they looked like red flags. She brought other men into the conversation without naming them.

“People always leave.”

“Men always change when they get comfortable.”

“No one really wants a woman like me, they want the performance.”

He tried to reassure her. Not with grand declarations. With quiet consistency.

“I’m not them.”

“I’m not going anywhere.”

“If I wanted the performance, I wouldn’t be here on a Tuesday when you’re tired and in the worst mood.”

She believed him for ten minutes at a time. Then the old logic came back, heavier than his patience. If he stayed, he could hurt her. If he left, at least she could say she was right. One evening, sitting in his car outside her building, he said something simple.

“You don’t trust me.”

She felt her chest tighten.

“I don’t trust anyone,” she said.

“That’s not true,” he replied gently. “You trust your fear.”

Silence. She laughed it off. He didn’t.

“Every time I come closer,” he continued, “you don’t ask if I’m safe. You ask how fast you could run if I turned out not to be.”

His voice was calm, not accusing. That made it worse.

“Is that a problem?” she asked.

“It’s a problem if you want something real,” he said. “I’m not asking you to pretend you’re not scared. I’m asking you not to punish me for things I haven’t done yet.”

His words sat between them like a mirror. She could see herself clearly in them. She did not like the reflection. So she did what she always did when clarity felt too close. She opened the door.

“I should go,” she said.

“Selah,” he called after her, “I’m not your past.”

“That’s what the past said,” she replied, and closed the door before she could see his face.

She did not text back for three days. On the fourth, he sent one message. I care about you. But I can't keep proving I'm not everyone who hurt you. No anger.

No ultimatum. Just a boundary. She stared at the screen. It would have been easier if he had shouted. If he had cursed.

If he had told her she was ungrateful, impossible, broken. Then she could have left cleanly. Instead, he left cleanly. Not dramatically. Not with speeches.

Just with less and less presence. He did not block her. He did not post subtweets. He did not tell the world she was crazy. He simply stopped applying for a position she clearly did not intend to fill.

Selah told herself it was better this way. Less risk. Less exposure. Less chance of waking up one day to find out he had turned into everyone else. But alone, she had to admit:

Not all men had been prison. Some had been mirrors. And mirrors scared her more than bars. Bars tell you where you can't go. Mirrors show you who you keep choosing to be.

There were other men. The savior, who needed her broken to feel useful. The buyer, who offered provision and expected silence in return. The poet, who wrote beautifully about emotions he never intended to protect. The one who claimed to be different, listening just long enough to weaponize her vulnerability the moment she disappointed him.

Selah had met them all. Sometimes she walked away before they did damage. Sometimes she stayed long enough to become someone she did not recognize. Soft in public, rage in private. Smiling at dinners, numb in bed.

Posting cute photos, deleting long paragraphs she knew they'd never really read. There were ex-lovers who told people, "She used me." There were ex-friends who said, "She only cares about herself."

There were ex□almosts who said, “She ran when it got real.” They weren’t always lying.

Sometimes she had used people. For attention. For distraction. For confirmation that she was still desirable even when she felt terrible. Sometimes she had cared more about her comfort than their confusion.

Sometimes she had run the second someone loved her in a way she did not know how to receive. She repeated the same sentence in her head: I am not a bad person. I am just protecting myself. But some nights, a quieter voice replied: At what cost?

It was easier to talk about the men who had hurt her. It was harder to think about the ones who had simply tried and failed because she would not stop treating them like suspects. The men were not always the danger. Sometimes the danger was what Selah did when someone came too close without trying to own her. Those men exposed something she could not blame on anyone else.

Her resistance. Her suspicion. Her addiction to leaving before anyone got the chance. She knew she had to stop calling every exit strategy wisdom. Some of it was just fear in high heels.

Later, there would be nights when she would sit in the dark, phone face down, thinking about the one who had almost stayed. She would remember his patience, his boundary, his sentence: You trust your fear. And she would hate how true it still was. But that part of the story belongs to another chapter.

For now, all the world saw was this: A bad girl who broke hearts. A woman who “played games.” A beautiful problem men warned each other about. They didn’t see the other truth.

That behind every door Selah closed in a man’s face, there was another closed in her own. The rumor said she didn’t know how to love. The reality was crueler: She loved constantly. She just trusted

leaving more than she trusted staying.

And every time a man walked away who hadn't tried to own her, she had one less excuse when she went to talk to God about why she was still alone.

Chapter 5

The Prayer

Selah did not come to God clean. She came late. She came tired. She came after things she would never post. She came honest, or at least as honest as she knew how to be.

Most nights, the world only saw two versions of her: Selah on display — sharp, dressed, composed. Selah desired — soft, laughing, chosen. There was a third version. The one nobody clapped for.

The one that showed up when the makeup was half-off, the shoes were on the floor, and the room finally stopped asking her to be interesting. That was the version that tried to talk to God. Sometimes it was in a hotel bathroom, the fan humming too loud, mascara blurred at the edges. Sometimes it was in the back of an Uber, forehead against cold glass, city lights dragging past like excuses. Sometimes it was on her own bed, phone on silent, silence on loud.

She didn't kneel perfectly. She didn't fold her hands the way children's books taught. She didn't start with "Heavenly Father" in the right tone. Mostly, she started like this:

"Hey. It's me."

As if God didn't know. As if she needed to remind herself that she was still someone in His direction, not just a rumor in everyone else's. She talked to God like someone who knew she wasn't innocent — but still hopes she wasn't lost.

"I know You saw that," she would say, staring at the ceiling.

"Let's not pretend You didn't."

There was no point performing for someone who had been in the room when she made the choice. Other people got to see the edited versions. God got the footage. She did not come with lists of good deeds. She didn't have many she believed in anyway.

Instead, she brought what she had: the drink she shouldn't have taken, the text she shouldn't have answered, the silence she used as punishment, the body she used as proof she was still wanted,

the man she pushed away before he had the chance to stay, the prayer she had postponed because she didn't want to stop.

"I'm not going to lie," she would whisper into the dark.

"I liked some of it."

There was a part of her that enjoyed being chosen, even for the wrong reasons. A part that liked the upper hand. The control. The exit on her terms. A part that thought:

If I'm already judged, I might as well pick the sentence. She did not hide that from God.

"What do You do," she asked once, "with someone who sins and doesn't hate every minute of it?"

No answer. Not the kind she could hear, at least. She filled the silence herself.

"I know, I know. Repent. I'm trying. It's just..."

She exhaled.

"It's hard to walk away from being wanted when you spent years feeling invisible."

Guilt, for Selah, did not come dressed in tears and dramatic music. It came as a heavy knowing. Knowing she had crossed lines. Knowing she had used people. Knowing she had chosen the rush over the truth.

Knowing she had treated forgiveness like an overdraft she could dip into whenever she felt like it. She didn't always cry after. Sometimes she scrolled. Sometimes she slept. Sometimes she stared at the wall and thought:

I'll talk to Him about it tomorrow. Tomorrow usually came in the form of a small, stubborn ache. In the shower. On the train. Between messages.

In the middle of laughter that felt slightly off-key. The ache said: You are not okay with this, no matter how pretty you make it look. When the ache got too loud, she prayed. Not the kind of prayer that sounds good in testimonies.

The kind that would make respectable people uncomfortable.

"God, I don't want to stop because I'm scared of hell," she admitted once.

"I want to stop because I'm tired of lying."

She did not ask to become a good girl. That costume had never fit. She did not say, "Make me pure." She said:

"Make me honest."

"Help me stop pretending I don't know what I'm doing."

"Help me stop using Your mercy as an excuse to keep playing with fire."

"Help me not turn every apology into a strategy."

Some nights, she couldn't even word it like that. Some nights, the prayer was just:

"I'm tired."

"I'm scared."

"I liked it."

“I hate that I liked it.”

“I don’t know how to be different without feeling empty.”

There were periods when she didn’t pray at all. Weeks where the distance between her and God felt too wide and too deliberate. She avoided His name like she avoided mirrors. If someone mentioned Him, she changed the subject. If a worship song came on, she skipped it.

If a verse appeared on her feed, she scrolled past it with a speed that gave her away. It wasn’t that she stopped believing. It was that believing made certain choices heavier. Disbelief can be a relief when you want to sin in peace. Selah never quite managed disbelief.

So instead, she compartmentalized. Bad girl by night. Almost-repentant by morning. Functional believer by Sunday. She hated the word hypocrite because it felt too neat.

The truth was messier. She wasn’t pretending to be righteous. She was dragging herself to a God she didn’t always want to obey, but couldn’t bring herself to abandon.

“I know what the church would say about me,” she confessed once, lying on her back, staring at a ceiling with faint water stains.

“But I want to know what You say. Not the quote version. You.”

Silence again. She had started to realize that a lot of prayer was surviving the silence without assuming it meant rejection. There were memories that only came up when she prayed. The first time someone crossed a line with her body and everyone told her to forgive and move on like nothing had been taken. The first time she apologized for something that wasn’t her fault because it kept the peace.

The first time she stayed with someone who scared her because leaving felt logistically impossible. Those nights, her prayers were less confession and more accusation.

“Where were You?”

“Why didn’t You stop it?”

“Why do You keep asking me to trust You with my heart when You watched it get broken?”

She felt guilty even thinking it. But she said it anyway. If God was real, He already knew the questions. Hiding them would not make her more holy. Just more fake.

She didn’t expect thunder. She didn’t expect a voice. Sometimes the only answer she got was the fact that she was still praying. There was one prayer she repeated more than any other.

“Please don’t let me become what they think I am.”

Not “make them see I’m good.” Not “clear my name.” Just: Don’t let the rumor become the truth by repetition.

“Don’t let me drown in the character,” she added once.

“Don’t let me lose the girl You actually made under the girl I perform to survive.”

She was not naïve. She knew she was not a victim in every story. She knew she had volunteered for some of the chaos. She knew she had enjoyed playing with matches and then asking why everything smelled like smoke. She brought that knowledge into prayer too.

“Sometimes I used people because I was tired of being the one people used first,” she said one night, in a hotel bathroom, sitting on the closed toilet lid, heels abandoned on the floor.

“I’m not going to pretend that makes it better.”

She looked at the phone in her hand. A message she had no business answering. A man in the next room who thought he knew her because he knew her body.

“I just don’t know where to put all this.”

There was makeup on the towel. Music still pulsing somewhere below the floor. Her reflection staring back, looking more human than the woman everyone posted about.

“Do You get tired of this?” she asked.

“Tired of me saying I’ll do better and then booking the same rooms with different people?”

No thunder. No voice. Just the small violence of being unable to lie convincingly to God. She rested her forehead against the cool glass.

“I don’t want to be good,” she admitted quietly.

“I want to be free.”

A beat.

“Teach me the difference.”

That was the closest she came to surrender some nights. She didn’t hand over her whole life. She handed over the parts that hurt the most and hoped it counted. Sometimes, after club nights, the Uber felt like a confessional. Heels off.

Bare feet on the car mat. Hair falling out of place. The driver minding his own business. The city blurring into streaks of color. God, I’m not proud of tonight, she would think, not out loud but loud enough.

I know I’ll be tempted to dress this up tomorrow. To call it closure. To call it empowerment. To call it experience. A sigh.

Please don’t let me lie to myself successfully. That was her most dangerous fear. Not being judged by others. Being so good at performance that she could no longer hear the difference between her narrative and the truth. She knew how to sell a story.

She knew how to write a caption that made wreckage look poetic. She knew how to spin sin into self-discovery when she didn't want to own the harm. She did not want to do that with God. If I can't be real here, she thought, where does that leave me? There were better believers than her.

People with cleaner testimonies, sharper discipline, less public contradiction. She did not compete with them. She envied their simplicity sometimes, but she did not pretend to be them.

"Look," she said once, out loud, in her own room, the air thick with the ghost of last night's perfume, "I'm not promising You perfection. We both know that would be a lie."

"I'm promising You interruptions."

"I'm promising that even when I go where I shouldn't, I'll still come back and talk to You about it."

"I'm promising I won't cut You out of the story just because I don't like my role."

It was an odd kind of vow. Not "I'll never fall again," but: You'll always hear about it from me, not just from the consequences. It wasn't theology-correct. It wasn't tidy.

But it was hers. Somewhere between Rumor and Body and Men and Money, her prayers became less about asking for things and more about asking not to be swallowed.

"Don't let me disappear into this version of myself," she whispered once, fingers pressed against the small cross at her neck.

"Don't let bad girl be the only name that feels true."

She did not ask God to erase the past. She asked Him not to let the past become her whole identity.

“If You’re going to save me,” she said, honest to the edge of disrespect, “save me from the parts I enjoy that are slowly killing me.”

There was a time when she thought repentance meant coming to God only after she had cleaned up. Now she was starting to suspect that the only real repentance she had ever done was showing up messy and refusing to pretend otherwise. She talked to God like someone who knew she was guilty — but still believed He might want the real her more than the well-dressed lie. She didn’t promise to stop being a bad girl. She didn’t even know exactly what that meant anymore.

She just prayed, again and again, in bathrooms and cars and beds and quiet rooms:

“Teach me how to tell the truth.”

“Even when it makes me look worse.”

“Especially then.”

And somewhere in the space between the last drink and the first tear, between the last “I’m fine” and the first “I’m not,” Selah began to realize: God was the only place she could not sell the character without seeing the cost. Everyone else could be impressed. He was not. Everyone else could be fooled.

He was not. And that, strangely, was the only thing that made her feel remotely safe.

Chapter 6

The Things She Did Anyway

There were things Selah did that no rumor invented. That was the problem. Not everything was projection. Not everything was jealousy. Not everything was men misunderstanding her boundaries or women resenting her freedom or church people confusing beauty with rebellion.

Some things were simply true. She had lied. She had used people. She had stayed in conversations because she liked being wanted, even when she knew she had no intention of being available. She had let people confess feelings she did not plan to honor.

She had tested love until it broke, then called the breaking proof. She had confused being untouchable with being unaccountable. And for a long time, she had called all of it protection. It was easier that way. Protection sounded clean.

Protection sounded wise. Protection sounded like something a woman had the right to do after the world had handled her carelessly. But not everything Selah called protection was protection. Sometimes it was fear. Sometimes it was pride.

Sometimes it was punishment. Sometimes it was just cruelty with better lighting. This was not about the things that had been done to her. This was about the things she did anyway. No one forced her to keep three separate conversations going just so she would never feel ignored.

No one forced her to write “I miss you” when what she really meant was “Don’t forget me.” No one forced her to answer late on

purpose, to watch messages pile up and feel important by delay. No one forced her to say “soon” when she knew she would never show up. Pain had shaped her. Yes.

But pain had also become her favorite defense in court. If she ever had to explain herself, she knew exactly what to say.

“I was hurt.”

“I was scared.”

“I didn’t know better.”

“I was just trying to survive.”

All of that had been true once. Some of it was still true now. But it was not the whole truth. The whole truth included the nights she saw clearly and chose the selfish thing anyway. The moment she looked at a message from someone who genuinely cared and thought:

If I answer now, this might become real. Then put the phone face down. The moment she stood in front of a mirror before a date and knew, deep down, that she was not emotionally available, but decided to go anyway because she wanted to be looked at like that. The moment she caught herself enjoying the way two men in the same room glanced at her differently, and let the tension hang because it made her feel powerful. No trauma had pushed the button for her.

Her own finger had. Some choices were not reflex. They were preference. Not everything Selah did came from pain. Some of it came from power.

And she liked that. There were people in Selah’s life who were never really people to her. They were mirrors. The friend she only called when she needed to hear, “You’re too good for them.” The man she only replied to when her ego was low, because his attention was guaranteed.

The ex she kept unblocked, not because she wanted him back, but because it comforted her to see he still watched her stories. They were reflections of a self she wanted to believe in: Desired. Irreplaceable. Worth chasing.

She did not always ask what it cost them to keep holding that mirror up. She told herself she was being clear.

“I never promised anything.”

“I never said we were serious.”

“They knew what this was.”

Sometimes that was true. Sometimes it was not. Sometimes she let people assume. Sometimes she fed the assumption. Stayed on the phone longer than necessary.

Asked intimate questions she had no intention of following through on. Shared pieces of her story just enough to make them feel special, not enough to make her feel exposed. She liked how it felt to be seen, even if she had no plans to let them touch what they were seeing. She liked being someone’s exception, even when she had already decided they would not be hers. There were nights she reread old messages just to remember what it felt like to be adored.

Not because she missed the person. Because she missed the version of herself in their eyes. She knew this was not innocent. There is a difference between enjoying company and enjoying worship. Sometimes she crossed it.

Then there was him. The almost-good man. He had his flaws. He was not a saint. But he had not lied to her.

He had tried to love her in a way that did not require a performance. And she had treated him like a suspect. Not because of what he did, but because of what others had done before him. She found small excuses to doubt him—a late reply, a canceled plan—and

called it proof. He left because he was tired of being tried for cases he hadn't committed.

Selah told herself he would have hurt her eventually. Maybe he would have. She would never know. Because she had hurt him first. It felt like proof that she could break something good without anyone needing to be a villain.

Losing him was not like losing the others. It did not explode. It evaporated. Messages spaced out. Calls got shorter.

Plans stopped being made. One day she realized she had not heard his name in her own mouth for weeks. He had become what she said she wanted. Gone. But it did not feel like victory.

It felt like proof that she could break something good without anyone needing to be a villain. She could not blame rumor for that. She could not blame men as a category. This one had not tried to own her. He had tried to hold her.

She had treated his arms like a trap anyway. There were sentences Selah repeated like a script. They made her feel understood. They also made it easy to avoid responsibility.

"I act like this because of what happened to me."

"I don't trust because trust got me hurt."

"I reject before I can be rejected."

There was truth in all of it. There was also hiding. The ugliest sentence she ever admitted was the one that changed everything. Sometimes I used people because I was tired of being the one people used first. That did not make it right. It only made it true. She said it once in a prayer.

Then once to a friend. Then once, quietly, to herself in the mirror. It tasted like metal and medicine. It shut a lot of doors. On self-pity.

On clean victim narratives. On the comfort of always pointing at someone else. Once she admitted that, she could no longer pretend every sharpness was self-defense. Sometimes she had been the blade. There were people who stopped trusting her.

Not because of what they heard. Because of what they experienced. Friends who stopped telling her secrets because they saw how easily she could weaponize information when she felt cornered. Men who stopped calling because they realized love was not a game they were willing to keep losing just to prove a point in her head. Women who kept their distance, not out of jealousy, but out of exhaustion.

She didn't lose everyone in explosions. Sometimes they just faded. Stopped inviting her. Stopped updating her. Stopped assuming she would be there when things were heavy instead of just when things were interesting.

No one staged an intervention. They simply adjusted their expectations.

“Selah doesn't show up for the hard parts.”

“Selah disappears when it's not about her.”

“Selah makes everything a test.”

Some of that was harsh. Some of it was deserved. The hardest loss was not the loud exit. It was the quiet shift. The way someone's eyes changed when they realized:

I cannot rely on you. The way a conversation went slightly more surface because the other person had already decided: I will not risk being this honest with you again. There were messages she never received because people wrote them, remembered who she had been before, and deleted them instead. Not everyone left in anger.

Some left in self-respect. She had become, for a few of them, the very thing she feared most in others: Unreliable. Emotionally unsafe. A beautiful risk they could no longer afford.

Selah had told herself for years that being hurt had made her wiser. In some ways, it had. She could see red flags quickly. She could smell manipulation. She could spot hypocrisy in three texts or less.

But what she had not wanted to admit was this: Being hurt had not stopped her from hurting people. It had just given her more sophisticated language to justify it. She had called it boundaries when really she was building a locked room and blaming people for not having the key. She had called it peace when really it was silence with teeth.

She had called it choosing herself when really she was choosing not to look at the damage she had left behind. There was a difference between healing and hardening. Sometimes she couldn't tell which one she was doing. This chapter of her life was not written in neon light. It was written in receipts.

Messages she reread with a wince. Memories that did not look as romantic when she removed the soundtrack. Apologies she never sent because "they're probably fine by now." She began to see a pattern she could no longer unsee: For every story where she could name someone who hurt her, there was another story where someone could quietly name her.

Not as monster. Not as abuser. Just as someone who had not been careful with a heart that had done nothing to deserve the impact. That realization did not erase what had been done to her. It just refused to let her use it as a hall pass forever.

Before the world ever put Selah on trial, she had already started hearing the witnesses inside her own head. Not strangers. Not commenters. Not church people. The man who had almost stayed.

The friend who had slowly stopped calling. The version of herself who remembered every time she chose power over kindness and called it healing. The bad girl had a story. So did the people who had met her halfway and gone home with splinters. In the end, this chapter was not about accusation.

It was about inventory. There were things Selah did that no rumor invented. And if she ever wanted to walk out of the character and into freedom, she would have to stop pretending all her sharp edges were sculpted by someone else. The next chapter would bring other voices. Ex-lovers.

Friends. Family. People with their own truths and their own wounds. But before anyone else took the stand, Selah had finally done something she had avoided for years: She had put herself there first.

Chapter 7

The Trial

Everyone told the truth. That was the problem. Not the whole truth. Never the whole truth. But enough of it to wound.

By the time Selah understood what people were saying about her, the courtroom had already been built. Not with wood. Not with marble. With screenshots. Half-told stories.

Voice notes. Prayer requests. Old messages. Women whispering over brunch. Men pretending pain was wisdom.

Friends calling distance “boundaries” because it sounded cleaner than disappointment. No judge entered. No gavel fell. Still, everyone took the stand. Selah had spent years being a rumor.

Then a body. Then a warning. Then a confession she was not ready to make. Now she was evidence. Exhibit A: the woman who left.

Exhibit B: the woman who stayed too long. Exhibit C: the woman who hurt people and still wanted mercy. The trial did not ask if Selah was good. That would have been too simple. The trial asked a harder question:

How much truth can a woman carry before people stop calling her complicated and start calling her guilty? No one said, “Court is in session.” It just was. The first witness was the man who almost stayed. He did not speak like a man looking for revenge.

That made his testimony harder to dismiss. Revenge has a smell. This was quieter.

“I loved her,” he said. “Or I was close to it.”

No one laughed.

“She made everything feel like a test I hadn’t studied for. If I texted too much, I was needy. If I gave her space, I was pulling away. If I remembered details, I was trying too hard. If I forgot one, it became evidence.”

He looked down at his hands.

“I don’t think she wanted to hurt me. That’s the part that still makes me sad. I think she wanted me to prove I wouldn’t leave. But the exam never ended.”

Selah did not look at him. Not because she disagreed. Because she remembered. The couch. The blanket.

The water on the table. The phone charging beside her. No hands where they shouldn’t have been. No price attached to kindness. She remembered how frightened she had been by a tenderness that did not immediately ask for anything back.

“I kept trying to show her I was safe,” he said. “But after a while, trying to prove you are not someone else becomes its own kind of prison.”

That sentence moved through the room slowly. Selah felt it arrive before it touched her. He was not wrong. That was the problem with the trial. The cruelest witnesses were not always the ones who lied.

Sometimes they were the ones who remembered accurately. The second witness was a friend. Not the fake kind. Not the jealous kind. The harder kind.

The one who had once known Selah before the reputation learned how to dress itself.

“She can be beautiful to be around,” the friend said. “When she’s present, I mean really present, it feels like the room gets warmer.”

Selah almost hated her for starting gently. Gentleness made the blade cleaner.

“But she disappears when life gets heavy,” the friend continued. “Not always physically. Sometimes she’s sitting right there, but you can feel she has left the conversation unless it reflects her somehow.”

Selah’s jaw tightened.

“I stopped telling her certain things,” the friend said. “Not because I didn’t love her. Because I didn’t know which version of her would receive them.”

There it was. A wound without shouting.

“She could make you feel chosen. Then she could make you feel like you had imagined the closeness.”

The friend swallowed.

“And when you confronted her, she always had language. Good language. Healing language. Boundaries. Peace. Energy. Trauma. She knew how to explain herself so well that you left the conversation wondering if your hurt was just bad comprehension.”

Selah closed eyes. Because she had done that. She had turned self-awareness into a shield. She had used the vocabulary of healing to avoid the labor of repair.

“I don’t think she’s evil,” the friend said. “I think she learned survival so young that she started treating normal love like an ambush.”

A pause.

“But being hard to love is not the same as being allowed to be careless.”

The friend stepped down. She had not lied. She had not said everything. The next voice was the rival. She would never call herself

that.

Rivals rarely do.

“I don’t hate her,” the woman said. “People like to say that. It’s not true. I don’t hate her.”

She adjusted a bracelet that did not need adjusting.

“I just don’t like what she represents.”

There it was.

“She walks into a room and acts like she doesn’t have to earn her place there. Like being beautiful and mysterious is enough.”

She laughed, short and sharp.

“Maybe it is. For her.”

She talked about the dresses. The looks. The way conversation shifted when Selah entered a space.

“It’s not that she’s the only pretty woman in the room,” the rival said. “It’s that she refuses to be grateful for the attention. She acts like she expects it.”

She leaned forward slightly.

“And I think that bothers people. It bothers me.”

For a moment, honesty cracked through envy.

“I spent years being careful,” she admitted. “Careful what I wore, careful how loud I laughed, careful how much I asked for. I did everything right.”

Her mouth tightened.

“And still watched men who called me ‘wife material’ look at women like her like they had been thirsty their whole lives.”

She exhaled.

“So yes. I judged her. I called her reckless. I said she was what’s wrong with women today. But if I’m being honest, sometimes I wasn’t sure if I wanted to protect the world from her or protect myself from the fact that I wanted some of that freedom.”

She sat back.

“I don’t know if she’s as powerful as she looks. I just know that when she walks away from a man, he doesn’t usually come back to us acting the same.”

Selah heard the accusation behind the words. Not “you stole them.”

“You woke up a hunger in them we now have to deal with.”

The rival stepped down. She had told the truth. Just not all of it. The third witness came from the church. Not old enough to be harmless.

Not young enough to be impressed. She wore concern like a pressed blouse.

“Selah has a spirit that wrestles,” she said.

People nodded because that sounded kind. Selah knew better. In church, people had a way of turning diagnosis into prayer.

“She loves God,” the woman continued. “I believe that. But she also loves being untouchable.”

Selah looked up. That was not what she expected.

“She comes to God, yes. But sometimes she comes with one hand open and the other hand still holding the thing that is destroying her.”

The room went quiet. The woman’s voice softened.

“I am not saying this to shame her. God knows we all have something. But Selah sometimes mistakes being honest about sin for

being free from its power.”

Selah felt heat rise behind her eyes. Not tears. Recognition.

“She thinks because she names the thing, it cannot own her,” the woman said. “But naming a chain is not the same as breaking it.”

That landed like a verdict. The woman looked at her then. Not with envy. Not with disgust. With something worse.

Mercy.

“And still,” she said, “I believe God has not stopped calling her by the name He gave her before the world gave her another one.”

Selah did not know whether to be grateful or offended. The church woman stepped down. She had told the truth. But even mercy has fingerprints. Even concern can carry things it does not confess.

The next voice did not belong to a lover, a rival, or a saint. It belonged to someone who had watched Selah longer than most. She was not her mother. But she had earned the right to sound like one.

“You learned to survive too young,” she said simply. “And then you forgot survival is not the same as living.”

Selah’s throat tightened.

“You were praised for being strong,” the woman continued. “For being the girl who didn’t cry, who didn’t break, who could handle things.”

She shook her head.

“No one told you that being applauded for your strength can feel a lot like being abandoned in your weakness.”

She spoke of years when Selah had to be older than she was. Rooms where she read adult moods like weather reports. Situations where she swallowed her own fear to make other people feel less

guilty.

“You got good at reading danger,” the woman said. “So good that you started seeing it everywhere. Even in love. Even in rest. Even in God.”

She sighed.

“I do not excuse what you’ve done. The lies. The tests. The disappearing acts. The way you’ve held people’s hearts like they were overdue debts.”

Selah flinched.

“But I also will not pretend you became this woman in a vacuum.”

The mother figure’s voice steadied.

“You are responsible for what you do with your pain. Yes. But others are responsible for giving you so much of it before you even knew what to call it.”

She looked at Selah. Really looked.

“The danger now is not that you stay broken,” she said. “The danger is that you build a throne on your brokenness and call it identity.”

Silence.

“You are more than what hurt you. And more than what you did to others because of it.”

She stepped down. Her testimony cut both ways. It defended. It indicted. It refused to let Selah be only victim or only villain.

Finally, it was her turn. No one announced it. There was no official call. But there comes a moment in every trial when the room silently turns toward the one on the stand. Selah did not rise with drama.

She just straightened her back. Everyone had spoken around her. About her. Over her. Now it was her voice that sounded strange.

“Everyone told the truth,” she said quietly. “That’s what makes this so complicated.”

She took a breath.

“My ex is right. I turned love into an exam with no final. I was more invested in not being wrong about people than I was in letting them be right for me.”

Another breath.

“My friend is right. I used language as a shield. I know all the words — healing, boundaries, trauma, triggers. I know how to arrange them so I sound self-aware while avoiding the part where I actually change.”

Her mouth twisted into something that wasn’t quite a smile.

“The rival is right too. I like walking into a room like I belong there. I like not acting grateful for attention I didn’t ask for. I know that disturbs people who were taught to earn what I sometimes just receive.”

She did not apologize for that.

“The church woman is right. I confuse confession with transformation. I think because I can list my sins in good sentences, I’m somehow free. I’m not. I’m just articulate.”

Her voice wavered, then steadied.

“And she’s also right that I love being untouchable. Because being touchable, historically, has not gone well for me.”

She swallowed.

“And the mother is right. I did learn survival too young. And I have built a personality around it.”

She let the weight of that sit.

“I am not here to say, ‘You’re all wrong about me.’”

She shook her head.

“I am here to say, ‘You’re all right about a part of me. None of you know the whole.’”

She looked down at her own hands, remembering the things she had already forced herself to admit.

“I have hurt people. I have enjoyed power. I have used my pain as cover. I have used my beauty as leverage. I have treated God like a witness I only call after the damage instead of a Father I walk with before it.”

She exhaled slowly.

“But I am also the girl who still prays after clubs. Who still feels sick when she lies too well. Who still wants to be known beyond the rumor, even when she is the one adding to it.”

No one clapped. This was not that kind of speech.

“The truth is not a single sentence,” Selah said. “It is a room none of us can see all at once.”

She looked around at the invisible crowd.

“You saw the parts of me that hurt you, scared you, threatened you, disappointed you, confused you. You told the truth about those parts. I won’t take that away from you.”

Her jaw set.

“But I will not let your chapter be my whole book.”

There it was. Not a defense. Not exactly. More like a closing statement with no verdict attached yet. In proper trials, someone decides.

Guilty. Not guilty. Case dismissed. In real life, no such clarity exists. The ex-lover left before the ending.

The friend adjusted her expectations. The rival kept watching from a distance. The church woman kept praying with one eye open. The mother figure kept loving with honest hands. None of them knew everything.

All of them knew something. Everyone told the truth. That was the problem. None of them told all of it. The trial did not end with a sentence.

It ended with a weight. The weight of knowing that Selah was exactly what the world had decided she was — and also nothing like it. Somewhere between their testimonies and her own, a question formed that would follow her into the next chapter: If all of this is true, then who am I when no one is watching, when no one is hurt, when no one is clapping, when no one is calling me bad or brave or broken?

The trial could not answer that. It could only strip away the comfort of pretending that everyone else had lied. Before the world put Selah on trial, she had already started hearing the witnesses inside her own head. Now she had heard the ones outside too. The next part of the story would not be about their voices.

It would be about what she did with them when the courtroom emptied and the only person left to testify was the one she kept meeting in the mirror.

Chapter 8

The Mirror

When the courtroom emptied, Selah was still there. No witnesses. No whispers. No one waiting to be disappointed. No one asking her to explain herself in a language they could survive.

Just the room. The silence. The mirror. Selah had survived being watched. Now she had to survive seeing herself.

That was harder. Being watched, at least, gave her something to perform against. A stare could become a posture. A rumor could become an outfit. A judgment could become a caption.

A man's desire could become a door. A woman's envy could become proof. A church woman's concern could become one more reason to arrive late and pray anyway. But the mirror did not negotiate. It did not flirt.

It did not misunderstand her on purpose. It did not clap. It simply returned what stood in front of it. And Selah was tired of being returned to herself. She stood in the bathroom with the light too bright and the door locked, though no one else was home.

The sink was crowded with evidence. Lip gloss. Cotton pads. A perfume bottle. A small cross she had taken off and not yet put back on.

A hotel key card from a night she kept telling herself did not matter. A receipt folded so many times it had become soft at the edges. Her phone, face down. A message unread because she already knew what it would do to her. She looked at the woman in the mirror.

Beautiful, still. Composed, almost. Expensive enough to be misread. Tired enough to tell the truth. Sometimes I don't know where the woman ends and the character begins.

She did not say it out loud. She did not need to. The mirror had heard worse. She started with the lashes. Not because they were heavy.

Because they were the easiest thing to remove without feeling like a confession. Then the gloss. Then the foundation. Then the careful face. One cotton pad at a time, Selah watched the woman become less useful to the world.

That was how she thought of beauty on the bad nights. Useful. Useful for entering rooms. Useful for leaving them. Useful for getting listened to, underestimated, forgiven, desired, hated, invited, blamed.

Useful for turning pain into something people could admire without having to help. Underneath it, her face looked younger. Not innocent. Just less defended. She hated that.

Innocence was not what she missed. She missed being simple. She missed wanting things without immediately calculating the risk. She missed being able to like someone without turning affection into evidence. She missed walking into a room without becoming a story before she had even opened her mouth.

She missed herself, sometimes. Or maybe she missed a version of herself that had never fully existed. That was the cruel part about healing. You can spend years trying to return to someone you only imagined being. The girl before the damage.

The girl before the performance. The girl before the name had started fitting too well. But Selah was beginning to understand that freedom would not come from becoming untouched again. That woman was gone. Maybe she had never been real.

Maybe she had been a hope people placed on girls before the world taught them what attention could cost. The mirror did not offer comfort. It offered accuracy. Selah leaned closer. There were no witnesses now.

No one to impress. No one to punish. No one to leave before they left her. Just the question: Who are you when no one needs you to be dangerous?

She waited, as if the answer might appear behind her own eyes. It did not. Only her face. Bare. Quiet.

Still difficult to love, maybe. But no longer hidden behind the performance of being impossible. She thought about all the names she had worn. Baddie. Bad girl.

Problem. Temptation. Gold digger. Heartbreaker. Difficult.

Dangerous. Too much. Each name had entered her life like a stranger and stayed long enough to move furniture. At first, she had resisted them. Then she had used them.

Then, without noticing, she had started decorating the rooms they built inside her. If they called her cold, she became colder. If they called her dangerous, she learned to enjoy the warning. If they called her expensive, she made sure cheapness never touched her again. If they called her impossible to love, she made love pass impossible tests.

There was power in becoming what people feared. There was also grief. Because every time Selah became the name they gave her, some quieter part of her had to step back. Make room. Lower its voice.

Wait. And that quieter part had been waiting for years. She could feel it now. Not as a dramatic awakening. Not as a holy moment with music and light.

Just as exhaustion. Deep, ordinary exhaustion. The kind that sits in the shoulders. The kind that makes silence feel heavier than noise. The kind that whispers:

I cannot keep performing this version of survival and still call it freedom. Selah touched the edge of the sink. Cool porcelain. Real. Not impressed.

Not disappointed. Just there. She almost envied objects for how little they had to explain. The character had saved her. That was the part she could not betray.

The bad girl had walked her out of rooms where the softer version would have stayed and tried to be understood. The bad girl had taught her to keep keys in her hand, money in her account, silence in her mouth, and God somewhere close enough to call when the night got too honest. The bad girl had looked men in the eye and said no. The bad girl had survived being laughed at, desired, doubted, touched, judged, and prayed about. The bad girl had built walls when no one else built shelter.

Selah could not hate her. Not fully. But she could no longer let her drive. Because the same character who protected her from cruelty was now protecting her from intimacy. The same silence that once kept her safe now kept her unknown.

The same exit plan that once saved her now made every room temporary. The same beauty she had turned into armor now made her afraid to be seen without shine. The same power that made her untouchable now made her lonely. The mirror did not ask her to kill the bad girl. It asked her to stop mistaking her for the whole woman.

That was harder than shame. Shame was familiar. Shame had rules. Hide. Dress better.

Act colder. Leave first. Pray later. But wholeness had no script. Wholeness asked questions Selah did not know how to answer.

Can you be desired without becoming a performance? Can you be safe without being unreachable? Can you be powerful without needing someone else to feel small? Can you be honest without making honesty another costume? Can you be loved without treating love like a trap?

She wanted to say yes. She could not yet. So she said nothing. The mirror accepted that too. There were things she had not told anyone.

Not God in full sentences. Not the almost-good man. Not the friend who had stopped calling. Not even herself without looking away. She was afraid that if she became softer, the world would take it as an invitation.

She was afraid that if she stopped being interesting, nobody would stay. She was afraid that if she forgave herself too quickly, she would return to the same rooms with better vocabulary. She was afraid that if she told the whole truth, people would not say, “Now we understand.” They would say, “We knew it.” That was the cruel trap.

The lie protected her from being exposed. The truth threatened to confirm the people who had already judged her. So she stayed between them. Not fully fake. Not fully free.

A woman learning to tell the truth in a world that had used truth against her before. Selah picked up the small cross from the sink. For a moment, she only held it. She did not put it on. She did not pray beautifully.

She did not promise a new life. She simply held it like evidence that she still wanted to be found by something that knew her before the performance.

“You still know my name?” she asked.

The question was barely sound. No thunder answered. No warm light filled the bathroom. No sudden peace arrived to make the scene easier to write. Only the hum of the light.

The faint traffic outside. Her own breathing. Still, she did not feel abandoned. Not exactly. Sometimes, lately, she had started to think that God's silence was not always absence.

Sometimes it was space. Space to stop performing. Space to hear the truth without applause. Space to become less impressive and more alive. She put the cross back on.

Not as a solution. As a reminder. Then she looked at herself again. No lashes. No gloss.

No audience. Just Selah. Or as close as she could get tonight. She thought of the rumor. The body.

The money. The men. The prayer. The things she did anyway. The trial.

All the rooms she had survived by becoming whatever would keep her safest. And she wondered, for the first time, what it would cost to stop surviving as a personality. The question frightened her. But not as much as it used to. Maybe that was where freedom began.

Not in the grand exit. Not in the perfect apology. Not in everyone finally understanding. Maybe freedom began in the small private refusal to keep lying when no one was watching. Selah wiped the last trace of makeup from the corner of her eye.

The cotton came away dark. So little evidence for such a long performance. She almost laughed. Then she almost cried. Instead, she breathed.

That felt honest enough. The mirror disappeared behind her. But something it had shown her came with her. The woman in the mirror did not look free yet. But for the first time, she looked tired of pretending captivity was power.

Chapter 9

The Exit

Selah used to think exits had to be dramatic. A slammed door. A blocked number. A flight booked at midnight. A dress still smelling like someone else's cologne.

Keys in hand. Heart in teeth. A clean escape from a dirty room. She had built a personality out of leaving. Leave before they lie.

Leave before they change. Leave before the voice shakes. Leave before wanting becomes need. Leave before anyone notices how badly you hoped they would ask you to stay. For years, leaving had looked like power.

Sometimes it was. Sometimes leaving saved her life. Sometimes leaving saved her dignity. Sometimes leaving was the only prayer her body knew how to answer. But not every exit was freedom.

Some exits were fear with better shoes. Some were punishment. Some were proof that she could still disappear before anyone got close enough to disappoint her. Some were just old wounds choosing the door before the woman had a chance to choose the truth. That was the part Selah was only beginning to understand.

The exit she needed now was not out of a room. It was out of a pattern. It started without music. No sunrise. No speech.

No caption. Just a phone on a table and three messages waiting. One from someone who wanted her body. One from someone she owed an apology to. One from someone who always made her feel powerful and empty in the same hour.

The old Selah would have known what to do. Feed the desire. Delay the apology. Keep the mirror polished. But something in her had grown tired of winning the same loneliness.

She opened the apology first. Not because she was ready. Because readiness had become another excuse. She typed slowly. No poetry.

No explanation dressed as trauma. No “I’m sorry you felt that way.” Just: I hurt you. I knew what I was doing.

I called it protection because that sounded better than fear. You didn’t deserve that. I’m sorry. She stared at the message until her thumb went cold. Then she sent it.

Nothing happened. No thunder. No relief strong enough to trust. No instant freedom. Just a message delivered.

Sometimes that is all repentance looks like at first. A small truth leaving the body before the ego can dress it. She waited for the ache that usually came after honesty. It arrived. Of course it did.

Her chest tightened. Her mind started preparing arguments. You should have explained more. You should have made sure they understood your side. You should have reminded them what happened to you first.

You should have protected the story. But Selah was tired of protecting the story more than the truth. So she let the message sit there. Delivered. Unadorned.

Unprotected. She did not check if it had been read. Not yet. There were other exits calling her. The easy ones.

The man who wanted her body had sent a message that required almost no courage to answer. A little flirtation. A little performance. A little reminder that she was still desired. That door was familiar.

It opened with very little effort and closed behind her with the same old emptiness. The other message was from the person who

made her feel powerful and empty in the same hour. There were people like that in Selah's life. People who did not love her well, but understood the character perfectly. They knew which compliments unlocked her.

They knew when to disappear and return. They knew how to make chaos feel like chemistry. They did not ask her to change. That was the danger. A person who accepts your damage is not always loving you.

Sometimes they are just comfortable living there. Selah looked at the message. Then at the mirror across the room. Not the bathroom mirror this time. A smaller one.

Less dramatic. Less honest, maybe. Still honest enough. She did not reply. Not because she was healed.

Because she was beginning to understand that not every invitation deserved her old reflex. There was no applause in that. No cinematic victory. Just one unanswered message. One small refusal to feed the version of herself that had learned to survive on being wanted.

She made tea. That almost made her laugh. Tea felt too ordinary for a woman people had spent years turning into a warning. But maybe ordinary was part of the exit too. Maybe freedom was not always a black dress and a door left open behind her.

Maybe sometimes freedom was boiling water. Washing a glass. Putting the phone down. Letting the night pass without turning loneliness into a performance. The room was quiet.

Not empty. Quiet. There was a difference. Empty demanded filling. Quiet allowed listening.

Selah sat on the edge of the bed, barefoot, with the cup warming her hands. She thought about all the names she had answered to—Baddie, Bad girl, Heartbreaker, Gold digger, Difficult, Dangerous, Too much, Untouchable. Each had entered her life like an accusation, turned into armor, and ended as a prison. The strange thing about a

label is that it can begin as something thrown at you and end as something you decorate. Selah had decorated hers beautifully. She had made distant look elegant, unavailable look like power, and loneliness look selective.

And people had believed it, because people love a polished wound. It asks nothing of them. Selah was tired of being admired for not bleeding where people could see. She did not want to become soft or sweet for public approval. Harmless had never been the goal. Whole was the goal. And whole, she was learning, did not mean without edges. It meant knowing which edges were boundaries and which were blades.

Her body had known the difference for a long time. It knew the exhaustion after winning arguments no one else was having, the tightness after leaving rooms she secretly wanted to stay in, and the cold difference between peace and numbness. She had called many things freedom—silence, distance, being hard to reach, being impossible to read. Some of those things had helped her survive, and she would not curse the version of herself that had carried her through. The bad girl had protected her. Selah would not curse her for that. But she would not worship her either. She would thank her. Then ask her to sit down.

There were rooms where she might still need that part of herself. There were men who still did not hear no unless it sounded like thunder. There were places where softness without discernment was not holiness, but danger. There were days when the world would still mistake gentleness for permission. Selah was not going to become naïve in the name of healing.

She was not going to hand her keys to the first person who called her beautiful without agenda. She was not going to confuse vulnerability with unlocked doors. Freedom did not mean abandoning protection. It meant no longer calling every protection a personality. It meant she could keep the keys without sleeping beside the exit.

It meant she could have money without trusting it more than God. It meant she could be desired without letting desire become proof of worth. It meant she could leave when she needed to, and stay when staying was not surrender. That last one was new. Staying.

The word sat strangely in her mouth even when she did not say it out loud. Staying had always sounded like risk. Like exposure. Like waiting for someone to change their mind. Like giving another person enough time to learn where the soft parts were.

But maybe staying did not always mean being trapped. Maybe sometimes staying meant giving the truth enough time to breathe. Maybe sometimes staying meant not running from the first discomfort that did not actually threaten her. Maybe sometimes the question was not: How fast can I leave?

Maybe the question was: Is this danger, or is this just intimacy? Selah did not know how to answer that perfectly yet. But now she knew to ask. That was something.

Awareness was not freedom. But it was the first honest map she had ever owned. The apology message buzzed. Read. No reply.

Her stomach dropped anyway. The old Selah wanted to grab the phone. Send another message. Clarify. Control the damage.

Manage the interpretation. Make sure the other person understood she was sorry, but not weak. Accountable, but not pathetic. Changed, but not begging. She wanted to fix how the apology looked.

That almost made her smile. Even her remorse wanted good lighting. She placed the phone back on the table. Let it be ugly, she thought. Let it be incomplete.

Let it be enough that it was true. That was harder than sending it. The truth, once released, did not always perform well. Sometimes it sat there. Plain.

Unimpressive. Unliked. Unanswered. Maybe that was why she had avoided it for so long. Lies were easier to style.

Truth had terrible posture. It stood there, awkward and necessary. Selah sipped her tea. It had gone lukewarm. She drank it anyway.

The night continued. No miracle interrupted it. No choir arrived. No old wound closed itself neatly. Her phone still had messages.

Her past still had teeth. Her reputation still lived in rooms where she was not present to defend herself. People would still say things. Men would still warn each other. Women would still study her.

Church people would still pray with complicated faces. The internet would still make theories out of photographs. The world did not stop calling her bad. That was never the point. Some people needed the old version of Selah because it made their own stories easier to tell.

If she was cold, they did not have to ask how they had handled her warmth. If she was dangerous, they did not have to ask what they had tried to take. If she was vain, they did not have to ask why beauty made them so entitled. If she was faithless, they did not have to ask why mercy made them uncomfortable when it landed on someone messy. Selah could not control that.

She had tried. Through silence. Through image. Through distance. Through performance.

Through becoming so unreadable that no one could misquote her without guessing. It had not worked. People guessed anyway. So the exit could not be from misunderstanding. She would always be misunderstood by someone.

The exit had to be from obedience to it. She no longer wanted to build her life around correcting people who were committed to the easier version. She no longer wanted to answer every accusation with a pose. She no longer wanted to treat every appetite as proof. She no

longer wanted to mistake being desired for being known.

She no longer wanted to believe that the only choices were to be soft and unsafe, or unreachable and alone. There was a third way. Whole. Not clean. Not simple.

Not harmless. Whole. A baddie is what they saw. A bad girl is what they judged. A free woman is what she was becoming.

And freedom, she now understood, was not the absence of consequences. It was the courage to stop lying about them. It was telling the truth even when the truth made her less beautiful. It was apologizing without turning the apology into a performance. It was keeping boundaries without building a throne on brokenness.

It was letting God see her before the night had a chance to edit her. It was choosing not to use someone just because she could. It was choosing not to use someone just because she had the power. It was staying in the room long enough to ask: Is this danger, or is this just intimacy?

And sometimes, when the answer was intimacy, it was staying a little longer. Not forever. Not blindly. Not without keys. Just longer than fear expected.

Selah stood and walked to the window. The city outside was still awake in small ways. Lights in windows. Cars moving through wet streets. A woman walking alone with her coat pulled tight.

A man laughing into his phone. Someone beginning a night. Someone ending one. For once, Selah did not feel the need to be seen by it. That was new too.

She did not feel invisible. She did not feel famous. She simply felt present. It was not dramatic. Presence rarely is.

She touched the small cross at her neck. Not as proof that she had become better. As proof that she still wanted to be found.

“God,” she whispered, and stopped there.

For once, she had no speech. No negotiation. No performance. No elegant confession. Just His name.

Maybe that was prayer too. Maybe sometimes the holiest thing she could do was stop decorating the wound long enough to let it be touched. The phone buzzed again. Not the apology. The desire.

The easy door. Selah looked at it. A part of her still wanted to answer. Of course it did. Freedom did not erase appetite.

It taunted appetite that it was not king. She turned the phone over. Then paused. No. Face down felt like fear.

Face up felt like discipline. She turned it back. Face up. Message unread. Choice visible.

That mattered. Not enough to call it transformation. Enough to call it practice. She picked up her keys from the table. For a second, the old feeling returned.

Keys meant escape. Keys meant control. Keys meant no one could trap her without a fight. But tonight, the keys felt different. Not less powerful.

Less panicked. There were still exits. There would always be exits. But for the first time, Selah understood: a door is only freedom if you choose it,

not if fear keeps choosing it for you. She put the keys in her bag. Not to run. Not this time. Just to go home.

The phrase surprised her. Home. Not a place she borrowed. Not a room she performed in. Not a bed she used to prove she was wanted.

Not a hotel with clean towels and temporary safety. Home. A word she had once distrusted because it sounded too much like depending on something. Maybe home was not where nothing could hurt you.

Maybe home was where you stopped hurting yourself just to stay ready for war.

She did not know yet. But she wanted to. That was enough for tonight. Before leaving the room, Selah looked once more at the mirror. No lashes.

No gloss. No courtroom. No witnesses. No one clapping. No one naming it transformation.

That was fine. Some freedoms arrive quietly because they are not trying to impress the people who called them impossible. The woman in the mirror did not look innocent. She did not look evil. She did not even look fully free.

But she looked less willing to confuse captivity with power. Selah smiled. Not the smile she used in rooms. Not the one that said, “you cannot touch me.” A smaller one.

Almost private. Almost new. Then she opened the door. Not dramatically. Not as an escape.

As a beginning. The world would still call her what it needed to call her. Let it. Bad girl was just the name they gave to her freedom. Selah was the name she chose to keep.

Author's Note / Afterword

Bad Girl Gospel: The Story of Selah began as a question:

What if “bad girl” was not who she was, but the name the world gave to a woman it could not control?

Selah is a fictional character, but her contradictions are human. She wants love without losing control. She wants freedom without losing softness. She wants God without pretending to be clean. She wants to be seen without being reduced to what people desire, judge, or fear.

This book is not about excusing every wound.

It is about telling the truth about what wounds can become.

A baddie is what they see.

A bad girl is what they judge.

A free woman is what she becomes.

About the Author

Sabino Pereira creates fiction, reflective books, music, and work about behavior, healing, discernment, faith, and modern life.

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